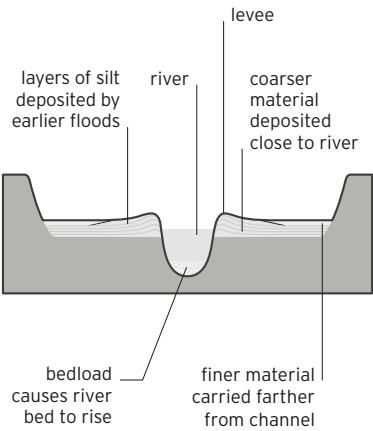


LEEVE ▼ A ridge of sediment deposited alongside a river when in flood, or an artificial embankment built to stop the river inundating its floodplain. See also *floodplain*.



LIGHTNING The visible flash that accompanies electrical discharges from storm clouds. See also *forked lightning*, *sheet lightning*.

LIMESTONE A sedimentary rock composed mainly from the skeletons of marine life forms such as foraminifera and corals. Chemically, limestones are mostly calcium carbonate. See also *karst*.

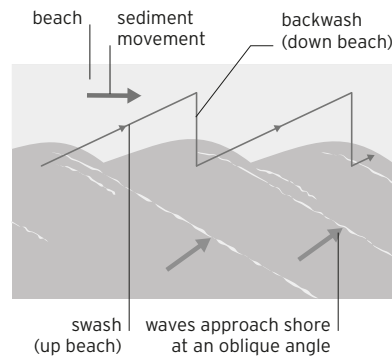
LIMESTONE PAVEMENT An uneven, blocky surface layer of limestone rock with crevices or fissures (known as grikes) separated by blocks (or clints), created by rainwater dissolving the porous limestone.

LINEAR DUNE A long, narrow desert dune that is aligned parallel to the direction of the prevailing wind. These dunes usually form where wind from one direction dominates, and they often form parallel ridges many kilometres long. See also *dune* (panel).

LITHOSPHERE See panel, below.

LITTORAL Relating to the shoreline, especially between the low- and high-water marks. See also *beach* (panel), *tide*.

LONGSHORE BAR A ridge of sand, mud, or gravel parallel to the shore in the intertidal zone or just seaward of it. See also *beach* (panel).



LONGSHORE DRIFT ▲ The transport of mud, sand, and gravel along a coastline by a current that flows roughly parallel to it. See also *current*.

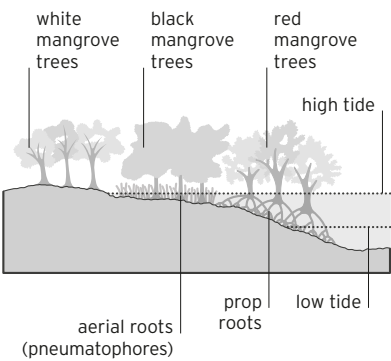
M

MAAR A shallow but steep-sided volcanic crater formed when magma comes into contact with groundwater to produce a violent steam explosion.

MAGMA Molten, or semi-molten, rock that rises from parts of the mantle into the crust. It can cool and solidify beneath the surface or at the surface. See also *intrusive igneous rock*, *lava*, *mantle*.

MAGMA CHAMBER A large underground reservoir of molten rock. Sometimes, pressure forces the magma contained within to push its way to the surface in an eruption. See also *caldera*, *plug*.

MANGROVE SWAMP ▼ An intertidal area where salt-tolerant trees (halophytes) thrive. Mangrove swamps are most common on shallow coasts in the tropics and subtropics. See also *swamp*.



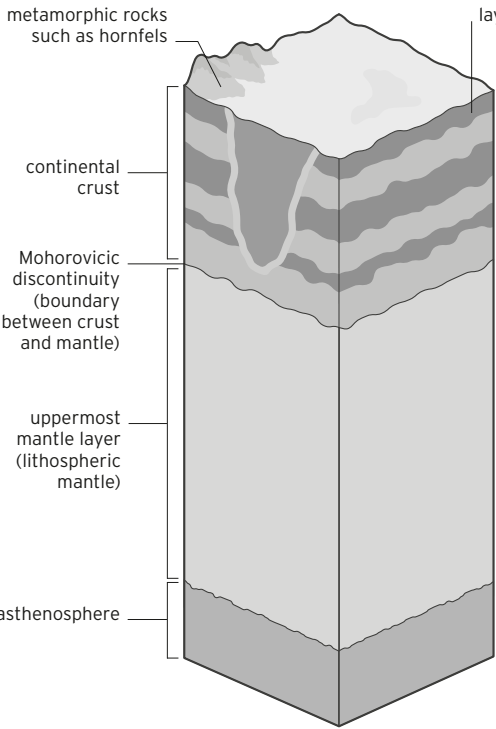
MANTLE The region of Earth's interior lying between the core and the crust. It makes up 84 percent of Earth's volume. See also *core*, *crust*.

MANTLE PLUME A column of hot rock that rises through the mantle and into the crust, giving rise to a hotspot, which is likely to lead to volcanic activity at the surface. See also *hotspot*.

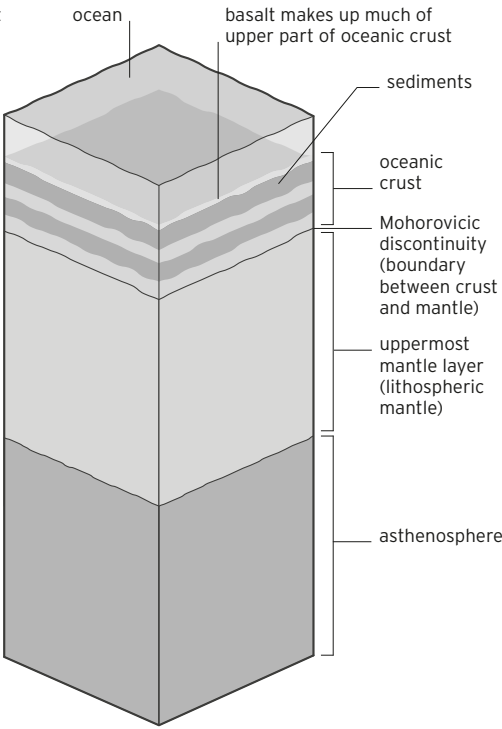
LITHOSPHERE

The solid, outer part of Earth, comprising the crust and the uppermost part of the mantle, is called the lithosphere. It lies above the asthenosphere, in which rocks are hot and viscous, and below the atmosphere and

hydrosphere. The oceanic lithosphere is associated with oceanic crust and is slightly denser than the continental lithosphere, which is associated with continental crust and may extend to a depth of 120 miles (200 km).



CONTINENTAL LITHOSPHERE



OCEANIC LITHOSPHERE